

- RAG Learning

1.6 Democracy and Participation

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 1 (Government and Politics of the UK)

This topic covers the nature of UK democracy, the extent of political participation, the history of the franchise, and the protection of rights. The recurring exam question is whether the UK faces a **participation crisis** — and the best answers argue about what the evidence actually shows rather than simply listing turnout figures.

1. Types of democracy

	Direct democracy	Representative democracy
Definition	Citizens take decisions themselves	Citizens elect representatives to deliberate and decide on their behalf
UK examples	Referendums; e-petitions triggering Westminster Hall debates	General, devolved and local elections
Strengths	Pure legitimacy; no distortion by representatives; educates and engages citizens	Representatives can deliberate on complex trade-offs; accountable at elections; can protect minorities against majorities
Weaknesses	Reduces complex issues to binary choices; vulnerable to funding and turnout effects; majority can override minority rights	Representatives may not reflect constituents; low turnout weakens the mandate; parties may converge

The UK is **primarily representative**, with direct democracy used mainly for major constitutional questions.

2. Features of UK democracy

- **Free and fair elections** — regulated by the Electoral Commission; universal adult suffrage; secret ballot.
- **Universal suffrage** — all citizens aged 18+ (16+ for devolved and local elections in Scotland and Wales). The Representation of the People Bill (introduced February 2026) would extend votes at 16 to all UK elections, including general elections, but it is not yet law (Lords second reading September 2026).
- **Party competition** and a functioning opposition.
- **Pressure groups and a free press** providing pluralist channels between elections.
- **Rule of law** and an independent judiciary.

3. The democratic deficit

Democratic deficit — a perceived shortfall in the accountability, legitimacy or participatory quality of a political system.

Standard UK examples:

- **FPTP disproportionality** — governments take office on 33–44 per cent of the vote — in 2024 Labour won 63 per cent of seats on 33.7 per cent; millions of votes have no effect on the outcome.
- **The unelected House of Lords** amends and delays legislation passed by elected representatives.
- **The royal prerogative** allows significant executive action without prior parliamentary approval.
- **Executive dominance** of a sovereign Parliament — Hailsham's "elective dictatorship".
- **Falling turnout and party membership.**

4. Is there a participation crisis?

Evidence for

- **Turnout** fell from around 84 per cent in 1950 to **59.4 per cent in 2001**, the lowest since 1918, and has not returned to post-war levels.
- **2024 general election** — turnout fell back to about **60 per cent**, barely above 2001 and the second-lowest since 1918.
- **Party membership** fell from millions in the 1950s to a small fraction of that.
- **Age gap** — turnout among 18–24s is consistently far below that of the over-65s, which skews whose preferences politicians attend to.
- **Local, devolved and PCC elections** frequently record turnout below 50 per cent, sometimes far below.
- **Declining trust**, accelerated by the 2009 expenses scandal.

Evidence against

- **Participation has shifted, not declined.** Membership of pressure groups and campaigning organisations — the National Trust, the RSPB — far exceeds that of all political parties combined. E-petitions routinely attract hundreds of thousands of signatures.
- **Turnout responds to stakes.** The 2014 Scottish independence referendum reached around **85 per cent**, the 2016 EU referendum around 72 per cent. That is not the behaviour of an apathetic electorate.
- **Party membership surged after 2015** — Labour's rose above half a million; the SNP grew dramatically after 2014.
- **Turnout recovered** to 67–69 per cent in 2017–2019 — though it fell back to about 60 per cent in 2024, which weakens this argument.
- Comparatively, UK turnout is not unusually poor among established democracies.

Exam Tip: The strongest analytical move is to reframe the question. The evidence is better explained as a crisis of **legitimacy** than of participation: citizens engage readily when they judge their vote will decide something (Scotland 2014), and abstain when they judge it will not (a safe seat under FPTP). That points at the electoral system and at responsiveness — not at apathy — and it changes which reforms count as solutions. This distinction, sometimes called "hapathy", separates top-band answers from list-based ones.

5. Proposed reforms

Reform	For	Against
Compulsory voting	Raises turnout immediately; corrects the age and class skew; used in Australia and Belgium	Manufactures turnout without engagement; may produce uninformed or random voting; arguably infringes the liberty to abstain
Votes at 16	Consistency with paying tax and joining the forces; voting is habit-forming; Scotland and Wales already do it for devolved elections; strong engagement at the 2014 referendum; the Representation of the People Bill (2026) would extend it to general elections, though it is not yet law	Maturity and susceptibility to influence; 18–24s already have the lowest turnout, so it may simply enlarge the abstaining group
Electoral reform	Addresses the strongest explanation for low turnout — safe seats and wasted votes; turnout is higher in marginals and under PR systems	Rejected decisively in 2011; the parties able to legislate are those FPTP advantages
Digital / e-voting	Convenience, particularly for young voters	Security and verifiability concerns; convenience is probably not the binding constraint
More referendums	Direct engagement on major questions	Binary framing; tension with parliamentary sovereignty; can entrench division

6. The franchise

Date	Reform	Effect
1832	Great Reform Act	Extended the vote to some middle-class men; began redistribution of seats
1867, 1884	Second and Third Reform Acts	Extended to urban and then rural working-class men
1918	Representation of the People Act	All men over 21; women over 30 meeting a property qualification
1928	Equal Franchise Act	Women given the vote on the same terms as men, at 21
1969	Representation of the People Act	Voting age lowered to 18
2014–	Scotland, then Wales	Votes at 16 for devolved and local elections
2026–	Representation of the People Bill	Would extend votes at 16 to all UK elections; introduced February 2026 and still before Parliament (Lords second reading September 2026)

The suffrage campaigns

- **Suffragists** (NUWSS, Millicent Fawcett) — peaceful, constitutional methods: petitions, lobbying, mass meetings.
- **Suffragettes** (WSPU, Emmeline Pankhurst) — militant direct action: window-breaking, arson, hunger strikes.
- Debate persists over which was decisive, and over the role of women's contribution during the First World War. Useful as a case study in whether direct action or insider campaigning works.

7. Rights in context

UK rights are historically **residual**: citizens were free to do whatever was not prohibited, rather than holding positively enumerated rights.

Instrument	What it does
Magna Carta 1215	Established that the monarch is subject to law; origin of due process
Human Rights Act 1998	Incorporated the ECHR; s.3 interpretive duty; s.4 declarations of incompatibility
Freedom of Information Act 2000	Right of access to information held by public bodies
Equality Act 2010	Consolidated anti-discrimination law around nine protected characteristics (applies in Great Britain; Northern Ireland has its own equality law)
ECHR membership	Cases may ultimately reach Strasbourg, independently of the HRA

The central weakness

None of this is entrenched. Because Parliament is sovereign, the HRA and Equality Act can be amended or repealed by an ordinary Act on a simple majority. Successive governments have proposed replacing the HRA — and since October 2025 the Conservatives have been committed to leaving the ECHR and repealing the HRA — and rights have been curtailed by counter-terrorism legislation permitting extended detention and expanded surveillance.

Exam Tip: A reformer proposing a British Bill of Rights faces a hard objection: **unless it is entrenched, it is as vulnerable to repeal as the HRA**. It would change the content of protected rights without strengthening their security — and entrenchment is incompatible with parliamentary sovereignty as traditionally understood.

Individual vs collective rights

Protecting the security of the community can require limiting individual liberties. Counter-terrorism legislation allowing extended pre-charge detention, control orders and bulk surveillance is the standard example; restrictions on protest under public order legislation is a more recent one. The tension is genuine and is not resolved by asserting either side.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Direct democracy	Citizens take political decisions themselves
Representative democracy	Citizens elect representatives to decide on their behalf
Democratic deficit	A shortfall in accountability, legitimacy or participation
Participation crisis	Sustained decline in citizens' engagement with formal politics
Franchise / suffrage	The right to vote
Mandate	Authority to implement a manifesto, claimed by a winning party
Pluralist democracy	Power dispersed among many competing groups, none dominant
Residual rights	Freedom to do whatever is not expressly prohibited
Hapathy	Disillusionment with the available choices rather than indifference to politics

Essential examples

- **2001 general election** — turnout 59.4 per cent, the post-1918 low.
- **2024 general election** — turnout about 60 per cent, the second-lowest since 1918, after a recovery to 67–69 per cent in 2017–2019.
- **2014 Scottish referendum** — ~85 per cent turnout, including 16- and 17-year-olds.
- **2009 expenses scandal** — collapse in trust in politicians.
- **Labour membership post-2015** — rose above half a million.
- **Equal Franchise Act 1928** — women on the same terms as men.

- **Belmarsh case (2004)** — declaration of incompatibility over indefinite detention; individual vs collective rights in practice.